

ERP Market Research Methodology and Project Direction

Date: 28 August 2026

Meeting Topic: ERP Market Research Methodology Refinement

Meeting Objective: To refine the ERP market research methodology, minimize research bias, ensure comprehensive feature analysis, and establish the direction for developing a modular ERP solution.

1. Meeting Purpose

The primary purpose of the meeting was to review and refine the existing ERP market research methodology.

The team identified the need to move away from high-level assumptions and generalized descriptions of ERP products and instead adopt a detailed, feature-level research approach. The revised methodology is intended to ensure comprehensive market coverage, reduce bias, identify relevant functionality, and support informed product decisions.

2. Key Takeaways

2.1 Existing Research Challenge

The current ERP research approach was identified as being potentially biased due to its reliance on high-level summaries obtained from AI tools, Google searches, and other secondary sources.

Such summaries may not provide a complete representation of an ERP product's capabilities.

For example, describing Oracle as primarily "finance-centric" may result in overlooking other capabilities provided by the product, such as:

- Procurement
- Supply Chain
- Inventory
- Other operational modules

Therefore, conclusions should not be based solely on generalized product descriptions. Individual modules and features must be reviewed in detail.

2.2 Risk of Incomplete Research

The current approach may result in a "mini-me" effect, where existing summaries influence the research and cause the same information to be repeatedly reproduced without sufficiently exploring the actual capabilities of the products.

This can lead to:

- Missing important features.

- Feature cherry-picking.
- Incorrect assumptions about competitors.
- Limited identification of market gaps.
- Development of a product that is primarily a copy of existing ERP solutions.
- Failure to leverage the team's existing domain knowledge and experience in the utility sector.

The objective should therefore be to understand the market comprehensively before deciding what should be included in the proposed product.

3. Agreed Two-Phase Research Methodology

The team agreed to adopt a two-phase ERP market research methodology.

Phase 1 – Broad Feature Collection

The first phase will focus on collecting all relevant modules and features from a broad range of ERP products.

The products considered for analysis include:

- SAP
- Oracle
- Microsoft Dynamics
- IFS
- Acumatica

Additional ERP products may be included where required.

Objective

The objective of this phase is to establish a comprehensive baseline of ERP functionality.

At this stage, the team should not immediately filter features based on whether they appear to be relevant or necessary.

Required Output

A comprehensive comparison matrix should be prepared containing:

- ERP modules.
- Sub-modules.
- Individual features.
- Availability of each feature across competitors.

- Relevant observations.

Features that are not available in a particular ERP should also be explicitly recorded using "X".

Missing features are considered important because they can help identify competitor gaps and potential opportunities.

4. Phase 2 – Feature Deep-Dive and Filtering

Once the broad feature baseline has been completed, the team will conduct a detailed analysis of selected features.

For example, Purchase Requisition can be selected for a deep-dive analysis.

The objective is to understand not only whether the feature exists, but also how it is implemented and how it interacts with other modules and processes.

Analysis Criteria

Each selected feature should be evaluated based on the following criteria:

4.1 Client-Specific vs. Generic

Determine whether the functionality is:

- Generic and applicable to most customers, or
- Specific to particular customer requirements.

4.2 Vendor-Specific vs. Generic

Determine whether the functionality depends on:

- Specific vendor processes, or
- Generic procurement/business processes.

4.3 User-Specific vs. Generic

Determine whether the functionality is:

- Applicable to a particular user or role, or
- Common across different users and business functions.

4.4 Scalability and Field Limitations

The analysis should consider:

- Number of fields.
- Configurable fields.
- Field limitations.
- Transaction limits.

- User limitations.
- Scalability considerations.

4.5 Modular Dependencies

The team should determine:

- Whether the feature can operate independently.
- Which modules it depends on.
- Which modules depend on it.
- How information is exchanged between modules.
- Whether the feature can be deployed independently.

Outcome

The outcome of Phase 2 will be a filtered list of must-have features that will form the foundation of the proposed product definition.

5. Objective of the Proposed ERP

The objective of the proposed product is not to rebuild another large monolithic ERP system.

Instead, the goal is to develop a modular and indigenous ERP solution that can provide selected capabilities according to customer requirements.

The solution should be designed to integrate with existing customer infrastructure where required.

For example, customers that already have an existing SAP implementation should potentially be able to adopt selected modules of the proposed ERP without replacing their entire existing system.

6. Modular ERP Architecture Analysis

To support the proposed modular architecture, the team must analyze how competitor ERP products structure and integrate their modules.

The following questions should be addressed during the research:

1. How do competitor modules operate independently?
2. How are different modules interconnected?
3. Are there mandatory core modules?
4. Which modules can operate as plug-and-play components?
5. What dependencies exist between modules?
6. How is data exchanged between modules?

7. How are external systems integrated with individual modules?
8. Can individual modules be integrated with an existing ERP system?
9. Can the proposed modules coexist with legacy systems?
10. What would be required to integrate with an existing system such as a long-running SAP implementation?

The findings from this analysis will be used to guide the architecture of the proposed ERP.

7. Research Documentation and Repository

All individual research conducted by team members should be consolidated into a single shared repository.

The repository should contain:

- Individual ERP research.
- Feature comparison matrices.
- Feature-level deep-dive analysis.
- Competitor gaps.
- Module dependency analysis.
- Modularity analysis.
- Compatibility analysis.
- Must-have features.
- Discarded features and modules.
- Rationale for discarded features.

All files should follow a standardized naming convention using dated and descriptive filenames.

Example:

2026-08-28_SAP_ERP_Research.xlsx

2026-08-28_ERP_Feature_Comparison.xlsx

2026-08-29_Purchase_Requisition_Deep_Dive.xlsx

8. Documentation of Discarded Features

The team agreed that discarded modules and features should also be retained as part of the research documentation.

The research should not contain only the final shortlist.

For every discarded feature or module, the rationale for exclusion should be documented.

This will ensure that:

- Previous research is not lost.
- Product decisions remain traceable.
- Features can be reconsidered in the future if requirements change.
- The team can clearly justify why certain functionality was excluded.

9. Shared AI Environment

The team discussed establishing a shared team account using Claude or an equivalent AI platform.

The objective is to ensure that project context is persistent and accessible to all team members.

The shared environment should help to:

- Maintain common project context.
- Avoid repeated uploading of the same documents.
- Improve collaboration.
- Reduce duplication of research.
- Maintain consistency across team members.

The team will reach out to N to provision the required team account.

One volunteer from the team will be assigned responsibility for managing and maintaining the usage guidelines.

10. GitHub Integration

The team will also explore integrating the research and documentation workflow with GitHub.

The objective is to allow documents and project information to be referenced directly rather than repeatedly uploaded.

This will also support:

- Centralized document management.
- Version control.
- Change tracking.
- Collaboration.
- Easy access to previous research.

- Maintenance of document history.

11. Formal Project Initiation

Starting from Monday, a formal project will be established involving all team members.

The project will focus on converting the market research findings into defined product requirements and development artifacts.

The initial project will target the following major deliverables:

11.1 Business Requirements Document (BRD)

The BRD will define the business requirements and core functionality of the proposed ERP.

11.2 Test Cases

Test cases will be prepared based on the finalized requirements to verify that the required functionality is correctly implemented.

11.3 Mockups / HTMLs

UI mockups and HTML prototypes will be developed based on the approved requirements and business processes.

12. Action Items

Sl. No.	Action Item	Responsibility
1	Adopt the two-phase ERP research methodology	Team
2	Collect all relevant features and modules from competitors	Team
3	Prepare a comprehensive competitor comparison matrix	Team
4	Record missing features using "X" or equivalent notation	Team
5	Conduct detailed feature-level deep dives	Team
6	Analyze feature dependencies and implementation approaches	Team
7	Classify features as generic, client-specific, vendor-specific, or user-specific	Team
8	Analyze scalability and field limitations	Team
9	Analyze competitor modularity and module dependencies	Team
10	Analyze compatibility with existing customer systems	Team
11	Identify must-have features	Team
12	Document discarded modules/features and their rationale	Team
13	Consolidate all research into a shared repository	Team
14	Follow dated and descriptive file naming	Team
15	Coordinate with N for provisioning of the shared AI account	Assigned Member / N
16	Assign a volunteer to manage AI usage guidelines	Team
17	Explore GitHub integration	Team

Sl. No.	Action Item	Responsibility
18	Establish the formal project with all members from Monday	Team
19	Initiate BRD preparation	Team
20	Initiate test-case preparation	Team
21	Initiate mockup/HTML preparation	Team

13. Final Outcome

The meeting concluded with agreement on the following key points:

1. ERP market research should be conducted at a granular feature level rather than relying on high-level summaries.
2. A **two-phase research methodology** will be followed.
3. Phase 1 will focus on comprehensive collection of ERP modules and features.
4. Phase 2 will involve detailed feature analysis and filtering of must-have capabilities.
5. Missing features and competitor gaps must be documented alongside available features.
6. Competitor modularity, dependencies, and system compatibility must be analyzed.
7. The proposed ERP should focus on a modular architecture rather than replicating a monolithic ERP.
8. Compatibility with existing customer infrastructure, including legacy ERP systems, should be considered.
9. All research should be consolidated into a shared repository with standardized file naming.
10. Discarded features and the rationale for their exclusion should be retained.
11. A shared AI environment and GitHub-based documentation workflow should be explored.
12. From Monday, the team will establish a formal project focused on the BRD, test cases, and mockups/HTMLs.

14. Conclusion

The revised methodology is intended to ensure that ERP product decisions are based on comprehensive research, detailed feature analysis, and actual business requirements, rather than assumptions derived from generalized competitor descriptions.

The research will serve as the foundation for defining the core product capabilities and designing a modular ERP architecture that can address utility-specific requirements while maintaining the flexibility to integrate with existing customer systems.